can think of nothing but good of him.' Akbar wrote to Aziz Koka, recalling their lifelong bond of affection, saying that the mirza was abandoning 'two Kaabas of flesh and blood; that is, his mother and Akbar, for a Kaaba of stone and mortar'. Even the Jesuits agreed that 'though often offended by his boldness, Akbar would seldom punish him. He used to say "Between me and Aziz is a river of milk which I cannot cross".'

That celebrated bond of milk and affection now appeared before Akbar in the form of Aziz Koka's long-suffering mother, Jiji Anaga. The old woman circled the Padshah's head with a cup of water and then drank the water. 'This night I had a dream that something untoward had happened to the Shahenshah,' she told the perplexed Akbar—she had taken upon herself the consequences of her errant son's actions. Akbar fretted greatly on behalf of Jiji Anaga. 'Should his mother die of grief for his absence,' he said of Aziz Koka, 'it will be hard for him to be delivered from the harshness of the world.' He wrote letters to Aziz Koka, chastising him for not seeking his mother's permission before leaving on such a perilous journey. He urged him to return immediately to console his grieving mother. On a more prosaic note, Akbar would also have been worried about the effects of the outspoken Aziz Koka's accusations against the Padshah's religious innovations on the larger Muslim world. In the end, Aziz Koka was undone by the venal greed of the sharifs of Mecca and, disgusted by their rapacity and considerably lighter in treasure, he returned to Hindustan. When he presented himself at court and prostrated himself before the Padshah, Akbar embraced him with tears in his eyes and immediately called for Jiji Anaga to relieve her of her 'dangerous sorrow'. Akbar restored to Aziz Koka his mansab of 5,000 and the mirza became one of the Padshah's disciples, much to Badauni's disgust:

> At this time A'zam Khan returned from Makkah, where he had suffered much harm at the hands of the Sharifs, and throwing away the blessing which he had derived from the pilgrimage, joined immediately on his return the Divine Faith, performing the sijdah, and following all other rules of discipleship; he cut off his beard, and was very forward at social meetings, and in conversation. He learned the rules of the new faith from his reverence Allami…

Aziz Koka would now remain at court till 1600, one of many formidable men and women who orbited around the Padshah and his sons, in an